

Session 3, *automated.*

A cross-domain automation library. Everything you learned today — the **Trigger** → **Process** → **Action** spine, AI-as-a-node, and building workflows in **n8n** — turned into concrete automations you can build this week, in your field, whatever your field is.

INSIDE

Your Session 3 toolkit, recapped
The Trigger → Process → Action spine
One fully worked automation
30 automations across 10 domains

DOMAINS COVERED

Operations · Sales · Marketing
Healthcare · Engineering · Legal
Finance · HR · Education · Support

What you walked away with today

Session 3 was your first real taste of automation — and yes, it can feel like a lot on day one. That is the point. These four building blocks are the foundation for the agents and connectors coming next. Before the automations, here is the toolkit in one view. **Every automation in this guide is built from one or more of these.**

SKILL 01

The Automation Spine

Every automation, however simple or complex, is three parts: a trigger that starts it, a process that transforms the data, and an action that delivers the result. Design it on paper, in that order, before you touch the tool.

USE IN: n8n • Zapier • Make

SKILL 02

Workflows & Nodes

Every step is a node; a chain of nodes is a workflow. Build node by node, pin your test data as you go, and run one node at a time so you always know exactly where an error lives.

USE IN: n8n (14-day free trial)

SKILL 03

AI as a Node

Drop an AI step in only where it earns its place — to extract, classify, generate, transform, or decide. Don't reach for a chainsaw to slice bread; most steps are plain logic, not AI.

USE IN: OpenAI node • any LLM

SKILL 04

Wiring Apps Together

Apps talk through APIs (the menu), webhooks (the doorbell) and API keys (the reservation), moving data as JSON. Learn just enough to connect two tools and let AI walk you through the fiddly setup.

USE IN: Sheets • Gmail • Tavily

THE ONE IDEA THAT TIES IT ALL TOGETHER

Every automation is **Trigger → Process → Action**. If the process is clear in your head, you can build it anywhere — Rule 1 is **understand the process thoroughly**, and Rule 2 is refer to Rule 1. So use Claude or ChatGPT to **think**, and use n8n to **run**: it is cheap, flat-rate, and a visible process you can debug.

Trigger → Process → Action

No matter what you are automating, every workflow you will ever build is these three parts. Get them clear on paper first — the wiring in n8n is the easy part. This is the single most useful card in this guide.

USE IT FOR EVERY AUTOMATION

Trigger → Process → Action

1 • TRIGGER

What starts the workflow — either time-based (on a schedule, every 10 minutes) or event-based (a form is submitted, an email arrives). Pick the one that fits the job.

2 • PROCESS

What happens to the data in between — filter, route, extract, classify, generate. This is where your logic lives, and where an AI node fits if the step needs judgement.

3 • ACTION

The result the workflow exists to produce — a row in a sheet, a drafted email, an alert. Design backwards from this: know the action, and the process reveals itself.

WORKED EXAMPLE • THE LEAD QUALIFIER FROM CLASS

The same three parts, built as one workflow

[TRIGGER] On form submission. A native n8n form captures Name, Email, Company and Project Description. The moment someone submits, the workflow fires — no polling, no waiting.

[PROCESS] An IF node checks the project description isn't empty (empty → park the lead). If it is there, an OpenAI node classifies it as a one-word "yes" or "no". A Switch node reads that word and forks the path.

[ACTION] A Google Sheets node appends the lead to the Genuine tab — or the Spam tab — mirroring the form's four fields. Genuine leads get worked; junk gets parked, automatically.

The classifier prompt — written by Claude, run by n8n:

You are a binary classifier for incoming project inquiries. I run a website-creation and automation agency. Decide if the project description below is a legitimate business inquiry or spam. Legitimate = clear intent, specific requirements, a plausible need. Spam = vague, generic, gibberish, or not requesting our services. Output only one word, lowercase: yes or no.

Notice how little of this is "tool tricks." It is almost all process design. Get the three parts clear and the wiring takes care of itself.

30 automations, 10 domains

Pick your field, or borrow from another — the building blocks transfer. Start with the one that solves a problem you actually have this week. Each card is tagged with the automation pattern it uses, and the colour on its left edge matches.

LEAD QUALIFY

DATA SYNC

CONTENT

MONITOR & ALERT

COMBO

= EVERY AUTOMATION IS BUILT ON THE TRIGGER → PROCESS → ACTION SPINE

01 Operations & Supply Chain

STOP THE MANUAL SORTING

Inbound Inquiry Triage

LEAD QUALIFY

Every “can you supply X?” message needs sorting from spam and tyre-kickers before anyone acts.

BUILD IT

On a form (or email) trigger, an **IF** node checks the required fields are filled, then an **OpenAI** node classifies genuine vs junk. A **Switch** routes real enquiries to a to-quote tab and junk to an archive — your team only ever sees real demand.

Low-Stock Reorder Alert

MONITOR & ALERT

Stock runs out before anyone notices, and reordering is a manual chore.

BUILD IT

A **Schedule** trigger reads your inventory sheet every few hours. An **IF** node catches anything below threshold, an **OpenAI** node drafts the reorder note, and **Gmail** creates a draft to the vendor to approve and send.

Shift Handover Autologger

DATA SYNC

End-of-shift notes are messy and inconsistent, so the next shift misses things.

BUILD IT

A form trigger captures the raw handover; an **OpenAI** node extracts open issues, blockers and safety items into clean fields; a **Google Sheets** node appends the row to a running log — safety flags first.

02 Sales & Business Development

REPLIES, NOT BUSYWORK

The Lead Qualifier

LEAD QUALIFY

The exact workflow from today. Chasing junk leads quietly burns your whole week.

BUILD IT

Form trigger → **IF** (brief not empty) → an **OpenAI** node returns a one-word yes/no → a **Switch** forks the path → **Google Sheets** appends to a Genuine or Spam tab. Simple, and it saves hours.

Personalised First-Touch Draft

COMBO

Every genuine lead deserves a reply that shows you actually did your homework.

BUILD IT

On the Genuine branch, a **Tavily** node researches the lead's company, an **OpenAI** node writes a tailored email as **JSON** (subject + body), and **Gmail** creates a draft. Create a draft, verify, then send — never auto-send.

CRM Sheet Sync

DATA SYNC

Leads from forms never make it into your tracker cleanly or consistently.

BUILD IT

A form trigger fires on each submission; an **OpenAI** node normalises name, company and role into consistent fields; a **Google Sheets** node appends the tidy row to your pipeline — no retyping.

03 Marketing & Brand

ONE ASSET, A WEEK OF CONTENT

Transcript-to-Content Fan-Out

CONTENT

A single webinar should become a week of posts, but repurposing is slow.

BUILD IT

A form/upload trigger takes the transcript; an **OpenAI** node generates one LinkedIn post, three hooks and a newsletter blurb as structured **JSON**; each is appended to a content-queue sheet, ready to schedule.

Brand-Voice Draft Gate

CONTENT

Everything the team drafts comes back generic or slightly off-voice.

BUILD IT

Trigger on a new topic, then an **OpenAI** node generates copy with your banned words and tone rules baked into the prompt. A **Switch** sends anything it flags to a review tab before it ships — context engineering, automated.

Campaign Lead Router

LEAD QUALIFY

Campaign form-fills need instant sorting by intent, not a Monday backlog.

BUILD IT

A form trigger captures the sign-up; an **OpenAI** node classifies by segment or interest; a **Switch** routes hot leads to the sales sheet and newsletter-only sign-ups to a nurture list.

O4 Healthcare & Medical

GROUNDED · ROUTED · REVIEWED

Intake Form Triage

LEAD QUALIFY

Patient enquiry forms arrive mixing urgent, routine and junk together.

BUILD IT

A form trigger feeds an **OpenAI** node that reads the free-text and classifies urgency and category; a **Switch** routes each to the right tab or team.

Decision-support only; a qualified clinician reviews every routing. Not a diagnostic tool.

Appointment Reminder Runner

MONITOR & ALERT

No-shows pile up because reminders go out manually, or not at all.

BUILD IT

A **Schedule** trigger reads tomorrow's appointment sheet; an **OpenAI** node drafts a plain-language reminder; **Gmail** creates drafts for staff to approve.

Follow your organisation's data-protection rules.

Referral Letter Structurer

DATA SYNC

Referral details arrive as messy free-text paragraphs.

BUILD IT

A form trigger takes the referral; an **OpenAI** node extracts patient, reason and priority into clean **JSON**; a **Google Sheets** node appends to a structured register.

A clinician verifies before anything is acted on.

05 Engineering & Software

SIGNAL OUT OF THE NOISE

Bug-Report Triage

LEAD QUALIFY

Incoming reports mix real bugs with noise, duplicates and half-thoughts.

BUILD IT

A form trigger feeds an **OpenAI** node that classifies severity and area and flags non-reproducible or spam reports; a **Switch** routes real bugs to a triage sheet, noise to an archive.

Build-Failure Alert

MONITOR & ALERT

Failures get noticed far too late, usually by a customer.

BUILD IT

A **Schedule** (or webhook) trigger checks your status endpoint; an **IF** node catches a failed state; an **OpenAI** node summarises the likely cause in plain English; a draft lands with the on-call engineer.

Changelog Draft Generator

CONTENT

Release notes never quite get written before the release ships.

BUILD IT

Trigger on a list of merged items; an **OpenAI** node transforms them into a clean, categorised changelog as **JSON**; a **Google Sheets** node appends it to a release-notes tab for review.

06 Legal & Compliance

SORTED BEFORE A LAWYER LOOKS

Intake Conflict Router

LEAD QUALIFY

New-matter enquiries need sorting before a lawyer spends a minute.

BUILD IT

A form trigger feeds an **OpenAI** node that classifies practice area and flags obvious non-fits or spam; a **Switch** routes genuine matters to an intake sheet.

Not legal advice. Attorney review required before you act.

Contract Field Extractor

DATA SYNC

Key dates, parties and renewal terms are buried in every contract.

BUILD IT

A form/upload trigger takes the document; an **OpenAI** node extracts parties, dates and terms into structured **JSON**; a **Google Sheets** node appends to a contracts register.

Verify every field before you rely on it.

Policy Breach Watch

MONITOR & ALERT

Nobody is watching the shared inbox for compliance issues.

BUILD IT

A **Schedule** trigger reads a submissions sheet; an **OpenAI** node flags anything that reads like a breach; a draft alert goes to the compliance lead to review.

07 Finance & Accounting

CLEAN DATA, EARLY WARNINGS

Expense Claim Triage

LEAD QUALIFY

Claims arrive with missing, vague or downright dubious details.

BUILD IT

A form trigger with an **IF** node checks required fields; an **OpenAI** node flags out-of-policy or suspicious claims; a **Switch** routes clean claims to Approve and the rest to Review.

Invoice Data Sync

DATA SYNC

Invoice details get retyped into the ledger by hand, with errors.

BUILD IT

A form/upload trigger takes the invoice; an **OpenAI** node extracts vendor, amount, date and PO into clean fields; a **Google Sheets** node appends the row to your ledger.

Reconcile against source before posting.

Budget Threshold Alert

MONITOR & ALERT

Overspend is always spotted after the fact, never before.

BUILD IT

A **Schedule** trigger reads the spend sheet; an **IF** node catches a category crossing its limit; an **OpenAI** node drafts a crisp heads-up; a draft email goes to the budget owner.

08 Human Resources & People

SELF-SERVE THE ROUTINE

Applicant Screener

LEAD QUALIFY

Application forms mix strong fits with spray-and-pray applicants.

BUILD IT

A form trigger feeds an **OpenAI** node that scores against your must-haves and flags junk; a **Switch** routes a shortlist to one tab and the rest to another.

Keep a human in the loop on every hiring decision.

Onboarding Task Kickoff

DATA SYNC

New-hire setup is a manual checklist rebuilt every single time.

BUILD IT

A form trigger fires on a signed offer; an **OpenAI** node generates the role-specific onboarding checklist as **JSON**; a **Google Sheets** node appends the tasks to a tracker.

Leave Request Router

MONITOR & ALERT

Requests sit unanswered in an inbox for days.

BUILD IT

A form trigger with an **IF** node checks dates and balance; an **OpenAI** node drafts an acknowledgement; the request lands in the manager's approval tab with a draft reply ready.

09 Education & L&D

MATERIAL INTO A MACHINE

Enrolment Enquiry Triage

LEAD QUALIFY

Course enquiries mix serious learners with spam and drive-bys.

BUILD IT

A form trigger feeds an **OpenAI** node that classifies genuine interest vs junk from the free-text; a **Switch** routes real enquiries to an advisor's sheet.

Quiz & Answer-Key Generator

CONTENT

Assessments take ages to write from scratch, every topic.

BUILD IT

A form trigger takes a topic and level; an **OpenAI** node generates questions plus an answer key as structured **JSON**; a **Google Sheets** node appends them to a question bank.

Assignment Intake Logger

DATA SYNC

Submissions arrive scattered across email and chat.

BUILD IT

A form trigger captures each submission; an **OpenAI** node extracts name, title and on-time status into clean fields; a **Google Sheets** node appends to a gradebook.

10 Customer Support & Success

RIGHT ANSWERS, FAST

Ticket Triage & Routing

LEAD QUALIFY

Tickets need sorting by urgency and topic the moment they land.

BUILD IT

A form/email trigger feeds an **OpenAI** node that classifies category and priority and flags spam; a **Switch** routes each ticket to the right queue tab.

Auto-Draft First Reply

COMBO

First responses are slow, and their quality is all over the place.

BUILD IT

On a genuine ticket, an **OpenAI** node drafts an on-brand reply as **JSON** (subject + body); **Gmail** creates a draft for an agent to check. Never auto-send.

CSAT Dip Alert

MONITOR & ALERT

A bad score slips through unnoticed until the account churns.

BUILD IT

A **Schedule** trigger reads the feedback sheet; an **IF** node catches a rating below threshold; an **OpenAI** node summarises the complaint; a draft alert goes to the success owner.

Your 20-minute starter

Reading isn't building. The fastest way to lock in today is to rebuild the lead qualifier in your own n8n, from memory — that is the exact capstone the session set, and it turns Session 3 from notes into a **working automation you own**.

BUILD YOUR FIRST WORKING AUTOMATION

Turn today's session into a workflow that runs itself

Be a cook before you are a chef: follow these steps exactly first. Once it works end-to-end, start changing one thing at a time.

- 1 Open n8n, start the 14-day free trial, and create a new workflow. Resist "build with AI" — go step by step.
- 2 Add an **On form submission** trigger. Capture Name, Email, Company, Project Description. Run it once, then pin the result.
- 3 Add an **IF** node (project description not empty → true), then an **OpenAI** node on a nano/mini model with the classifier prompt to output yes or no. Use the workbook's API key, or your own — about \$5 covers plenty of practice.
- 4 Add a **Switch** node (yes → Genuine, no → Spam) and two **Google Sheets** "append row" nodes. Unpin, then test end-to-end with one real lead and one obvious spam.
- 5 Stuck on a node? Copy the docs URL into Claude and ask for absolute-beginner steps. Build, break, fix — that is the whole game.

NEXT SESSION

Tomorrow moves from automations to agents: how to build an **AI employee** — a customer-support agent — in n8n. Everything you built today carries straight over. Same time. Come with your lead qualifier working.

"Don't say 'I want to learn automation.' Say 'I want to solve this problem' — automation is only the means to solve it."

— SESSION 3, AI ACCELERATOR PROGRAM